“Mom Is Fine. What Is There to Plan?”

Eight questions families ask about getting ready, and when to take yours to a professional.

Mom is well, and the family has started talking about getting ready. The same few questions keep coming round, usually near the end of a phone call, and nobody is sure who to ask.

Here are eight of them, answered in general terms. None of the answers is about Mom in particular. Where a question needs someone who knows her, the answer says who that is.

1 Mom is fine. What is there to plan?

Less than it sounds like, and none of it is a decision about where she lives. At this stage planning means getting a few things ready: what Mom wants, in her own words; what the family already knows, in one place; and who has offered to help with what. AARP's planning guide gives the reason for doing it: a plan helps everyone get on the same page, keeps the focus on what's best for the person it's for, and can provide some peace of mind. [1]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you'd like to know whether anything about Mom's health calls for more than getting ready. That's a question for her doctor.

2 What is useful to do now?

Preparation: anything that would help whatever happens. Asking Mom what she wants, putting the family's notes in one place, agreeing who keeps them and finding out what each person is willing to do all belong here. The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests writing down answers to questions such as what kind of assistance you can provide yourself, and what types of help friends and family members are willing to provide. [2]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you can't tell whether an item on your list is preparation or a decision. Bring the list to your care consultant.

3 What can wait?

Decisions that would commit Mom to something: where she would live, which place, and when. A plan made ahead doesn't need a guessed move-in date. How much care a person needs varies from person to person and often changes over time, which is one reason the roadmap leaves those decisions until there is something to decide them on. Write them down as things the family has chosen to wait on, which isn't the same as ruling them out. [3]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** someone in the family feels a decision can't wait. Ask Mom's doctor whether anything about her health makes it due.

4 Which change would bring us back to the plan?

In general, the kind you'd notice anyway. The CDC's advice is to update a care plan every year, or more often if the person has a change in health or medicines. The Family Caregiver Alliance says families should meet again when the caregiving situation, or other situations in family members' lives, change. Which particular changes should count for Mom can't be answered from a guide. [4] [5]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you want to know which changes matter for Mom in particular. Her doctor and your care consultant are the ones to ask.

5 One of us wants to start touring places and one of us won't talk about it. Who's right?

This guide can't settle that, and it may not need settling yet. It can help to notice that preparation and decisions are different things, and that there may be a list of useful things to do now that neither of them would object to. The Family Caregiver Alliance's advice for family meetings is to write the issues in a list as they're shared and not try to solve them until they've been explored. It adds that regular meetings put less pressure on everyone to get everything resolved in one sitting. [5]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** the disagreement is really about how Mom is doing. That's a question for her doctor, and a family can't vote on it.

6 Does Mom have to be part of this?

Yes. AARP's guide is direct about it: every family caregiving plan must center on the wishes of the person receiving the care, and a plan should never be made without her participation, knowledge and consent. The CDC's steps for a care plan start the same way, with a conversation with the person herself. Keep what Mom says she wants in her own words, separate from what the family hopes for. [1] [4]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** Mom would rather not talk about it yet and you'd like help finding a way in. Raise it with your care consultant.

7 The getting-ready keeps landing on me. How do we share it?

By making it visible and small. The Family Caregiver Alliance observes that siblings may assume the one who is helping has everything covered, and suggests asking directly, being specific, and asking for what's realistic. AARP adds that team members need not all live nearby or have huge blocks of time to be of value. A list of small pieces that people choose from is easier to share than one big job. [6] [1]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** the load is wearing on you. Say so to the family, and mention it to your own doctor.

8 Who do we ask when a question is beyond the family?

Questions about Mom's health go to her doctor. To find local services for older adults, the Eldercare Locator, a public service of the federal Administration for Community Living, is at 1-800-677-1116. The Family Caregiver Alliance describes professional care managers as people trained to assess an individual situation and to implement and monitor a care plan. [7] [2]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you can't tell whose question it is. Write it down and bring it to your care consultant, whose part in this step includes identifying which professionals need to be involved.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer any question about Mom herself, and it doesn't settle anything between relatives. Anything that depends on her health, her safety or what she would need is for someone who has assessed her.

Ready for the next step?

The general questions have plain answers now. The ones about Mom herself start from a clear picture of today, and that is what the care interview records: it goes through her situation one area at a time and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving at Home: A Guide to Community Resources
3. Administration for Community Living, How Much Care Will You Need?
4. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Steps for Creating and Maintaining a Care Plan
5. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
6. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving with Your Siblings
7. Administration for Community Living, Eldercare Locator

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